precisely because it was a peaceful movement. The peaceful character of her movement is precisely what won her the Nobel Prize.

The Rohingyas had every reason to hope that active persecution by the state would ease, and perhaps even that constraints would be placed on the Buddhist Rakhine extremists who perpetrated the recent 2012 and 2013 massacres against them.

Some actions by the NLD in 2015 and 2016 justified such hopes. The NLD had been allied with the Rakhine nationalist party associated with the 2012 and 2013 massacres, but the latter broke the alliance with the NLD on the grounds that the NLD was too tolerant of Muslims. For example, one consequence of this falling out was that the NLD only won 8 out of the 35 constituencies in Rakhine state in 2015. What is more, after the election, the NLD government moved to limit the influence of the sectarian, ultra-nationalist Buddhist monks allied with the Rakhine nationalists in particular over Myanmar's education system.

But these actions were not, in fact, signals that the NLD was taking the side of the oppressed Muslim minority over the ultra-nationalists. Rather, the motivation for the change in education policy in particular was more about the problems raised by the old legislation on women's rights in Myanmar. Even so, the fact that the NLD made a progressive move that went beyond what they had promised during the election campaign did feed into the emerging hope that in government the NLD might move the country in the right direction on all fronts.

It is no longer necessary to second-guess Ms Suu Kyi's and her government's motives and predilections. The faith the international community and the Rohingyas wanted to place in them can no longer be sustained. Hope has given way to despair, and sober realisation should be the order of the day. Under the patient eye of the Nobel Peace Prize winner, the Myanmar armed forces have already pushed over the border over half of the Rohingya population. Since 24 August 2017, some 500,000 Rohingyas have fled to refuge in Bangladesh out of a remaining population of less than 1 million. Ms Suu Kyi's September speech to the international community could not be more jarring in the circumstances.

Aung San Suu Kyi, however, is much more emblematic of this humanitarian crisis than one might expect just from her failure to live up to our hopes and expectations. If we dig beneath the surface, we discover just what views and ideologies make ethnic cleansing and genocide possible.